men who had accompanied him, and said something in Hindi, which I deciphered thus: 'You are playing with fire.' (*agni* is the word he used).

After thirty hours of standing sleepless, I collapsed. Someone took me to the bed where I lay semiconscious, but they thought I had passed out. The rest was all a mental haze, names floating in a stream of incoherent voices in and out of my bruised mind. That's when I first heard the name Sreekumar, who I later identified as that of a deputy director of the Kerala unit of IB.

'See these officers have vanished and now we are in trouble. What if something happens to this man,' a voice wafted in. 'None of the senior officers will own responsibility if he dies. That's why they never showed up after giving us orders to torture him.' In the depths of my semi-consciousness, someone's conspiracy was slowly unfolding.

I am not sure how much time elapsed before I opened my eyes to see just one person in the room. His outline was blurred, and it took a while for my eyes to adjust. As I lay there trying to remember what had happened, a bald portly man who appeared to be in his fifties approached my bed. I could make out that he was a doctor (Later I came to know he was Dr P Sukumaran from Krishna Clinic; he was called to revive me). He inspected me and found my legs swollen, the skin at the knees bruised and virtually bursting. I was bleeding. This was not from the beating—that was all on the head, neck and torso—but because of the thirty hours of standing.

The doctor then turned to the IB men who had entered the room, and said, 'Do you know this man is walking on a razor's edge. He may fall either side.'

I felt happy that someone was finally scolding my interrogators. The doctor gave me two tablets and left, saying, 'Let him sleep.' I slept like never before, so deep that there was no memory of falling into that abyss, no dreams, no pain, no concern of what would happen when I wake up.

I woke up when the door creaked open, letting in the harsh daylight.